Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

"HOW DID DECADES OF IMPERIAL RIVALRY AND FEAR CULMINATE IN THIRTY DAYS OF MADNESS?"

Pupil: _____ **Form:** _____ **Teacher:** _____



Historical Reference Map: The German Reich (1871–1918) — Geopolitical Encirclement & The Balance of Power

FORMATIVE HOMEWORK & RETRIEVAL LEDGER **30-SECOND DESK INSPECTION READY**

LESSON & ENQUIRY FOCUS	ATTEMPT 1	ATTEMPT 2	RETRIEVAL STRENGTH	PARENT SIGNATURE
1. German Unification & Bismarck *How was the German Empire created in 1871?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
2. Franco-Prussian War & Revanche *How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
3. Scramble for Africa & Morocco *To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
4. Naval Arms Race & Dreadnought *Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
5. Alliance System & Powder Keg *Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
6. Sarajevo & The July Crisis *Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	

Interactive Digital Revision Portal: Scan QR code for instant retrieval practice, flashcard vaults, and spoken teacher audio guides: *the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app*

MASTER CHRONOLOGY DOMINO FLOWCHART

1871–1914 • 14 Anchor Flashpoints from German Unification to Continental War

DOMINO FLOWCHART

Causal Chain: Trace how imperial rivalry, military alliances, and the arms race escalated into the July Crisis and the outbreak of the Great War.

1871 **German Empire Proclaimed:** Unified in the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles; Alsace-Lorraine annexed from France, sparking lifelong French *Revanche*.

1879 **Dual Alliance Formed:** Bismarck signs a defensive military treaty between Germany and Austria-Hungary against Tsarist Russia.

1882 **Triple Alliance Formed:** Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy create a central European mutual defense pact.

1890 **Bismarck Dismissed:** Kaiser Wilhelm II rejects defensive diplomacy, cancels the Reinsurance Treaty, and launches aggressive *Weltpolitik*.

1894 **Franco-Russian Alliance:** France and Russia unite militarily, trapping Germany between two rival powers (the two-front encirclement nightmare).

1898–1900 **Tirpitz Naval Laws:** Germany begins building the High Seas Fleet to challenge the British Royal Navy's supremacy.

1904 **Entente Cordiale Signed:** Britain and France settle colonial disputes (Egypt & Morocco) and begin joint defensive military discussions.

1905–1906 **First Moroccan Crisis:** Wilhelm II lands at Tangier to test the Entente; the Algeciras Conference (1906) isolates Germany and binds Britain to France.

1906 **HMS Dreadnought Launched:** Revolutionary British all-big-gun battleship resets naval technology and intensifies the Anglo-German arms race.

1907 **Triple Entente Completed:** The Anglo-Russian Convention settles Asian colonial rivalries, uniting Britain, France, and Russia.

1908 **The Bosnian Crisis:** Austria-Hungary annexes Bosnia, permanently alienating Serbia and humiliating Tsarist Russia.

1911 **Second Moroccan Crisis:** Germany sends gunboat Panther to Agadir; British Mansion House speech warns Germany, cementing Anglo-French solidarity.

1912–1913 **The Balkan Wars:** Balkan states defeat the Ottomans; Serbia doubles in size, escalating Austrian hostility and regional panic.

28 Jun – 4 Aug 1914 **The July Crisis & War:** Franz Ferdinand assassinated in Sarajevo → German Blank Cheque → Austrian Ultimatum → Russian mobilisation → Schlieffen Plan → World War.

LESSON 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & ALLIANCES

Enquiry: "How was the German Empire created in 1871?" • Direct Active Recall

Score: / 8 Q1–Q8

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

1. How many independent states existed in Central Europe before German unification? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

2. Which powerful military kingdom led the unification of Germany? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

3. Who was the Prussian Chancellor who engineered the unification of Germany? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

4. In what year was the German Empire officially proclaimed? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

5. Where was King Wilhelm I of Prussia crowned as the first German Emperor? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

6. What was Bismarck's primary foreign policy goal after 1871? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

7. What was Germany's greatest strategic military nightmare? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

8. What secret 1887 agreement did Bismarck negotiate to keep Russia neutral? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

LESSON 2: FRANCO-PRUSSIAN WAR & REVANCHE

Enquiry: "How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?" • Direct Active Recall

Score: / 8

Q9–Q16

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

9. Which French territory was annexed by Germany following the war in 1871? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

10. What was the French national desire for vengeance called? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

11. What was the size of the financial indemnity France was forced to pay Germany in 1871? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

12. Which treaty formally concluded the Franco-Prussian War in May 1871? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

13. Which French Emperor was captured by Prussian forces at the Battle of Sedan (1870)? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

14. Which ambitious young Emperor took the German throne in 1888 and dismissed Bismarck in 1890? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

15. What catastrophic diplomatic decision did Wilhelm II make immediately after dismissing Bismarck? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

16. What historic military alliance was signed in 1894 as a direct result of Wilhelm II's blunder? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

LESSON 3: SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA & MOROCCO

Enquiry: “To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?” • Direct Active Recall

Score: / 8

Q17–Q24

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

17. What term describes the rapid partition of the African continent by European empires (1881–1914)? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

18. Which 1884–85 conference laid down the imperial ground rules for annexing African territory? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

19. What famous slogan expressed Kaiser Wilhelm II's demand for a German colonial empire? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

20. What was Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive global foreign policy called? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

21. Where did Kaiser Wilhelm II land in 1905 to provoke the First Moroccan Crisis? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

22. Which 1906 conference resolved the First Moroccan Crisis, resulting in a diplomatic humiliation for Germany? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

23. What military action sparked the Second Moroccan Crisis (Agadir Crisis) in 1911? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

24. What was the decisive strategic consequence of the two Moroccan Crises for Anglo-French relations? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

LESSON 4: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

Enquiry: "Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?" • Direct Active Recall

Score: / 8

Q25–Q32

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

25. Which revolutionary, all-big-gun British battleship was launched in 1906? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

26. Which German naval minister directed the rapid construction of the German High Seas Fleet? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

27. What traditional maritime doctrine required Britain's fleet to equal the combined strength of the next two largest navies? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

28. What was Admiral Tirpitz's 'Risk Theory' (Risikotheorie)? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

29. What was the political slogan shouted by the British public demanding more battleships in 1909? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

30. What canal did Germany deepen between 1907 and 1914 to allow dreadnoughts to pass from the Baltic to the North Sea? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

31. How many Dreadnought-class battleships had Britain and Germany built by August 1914? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

32. Why did the invention of HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger Britain's naval supremacy? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

LESSON 5: ALLIANCE SYSTEM & BALKAN POWDER KEG

Enquiry: "Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?" • Direct Active Recall

Score: / 8

Q33–Q40

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

33. Which three empires formed the Triple Alliance in 1882? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

34. What term describes Britain's 19th-century policy of avoiding permanent European military alliances? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

35. What friendly diplomatic accord did Britain and France sign in 1904? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

36. What 1907 agreement settled colonial rivalries in Persia, Tibet, and Afghanistan, completing the Triple Entente? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

37. Why was Italy widely viewed as the 'weak link' in the Triple Alliance? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

38. What was the fatal structural flaw of the European alliance system? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

39. Why was south-eastern Europe known as the 'Powder Keg of Europe'? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

40. Which international crisis in 1908 brought Austria-Hungary and Russia to the brink of war? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (Detail / Why) to articulate the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

41. On what exact date was Archduke Franz Ferdinand assassinated in Sarajevo? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

42. Who was the 19-year-old Bosnian Serb nationalist who fired the fatal shots? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

43. What clandestine Serbian military terrorist organisation trained and armed the assassins? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

44. Why did Austria-Hungary's annexation of Bosnia in 1908 cause fury in Serbia? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

45. What was Germany's famous 'Blank Cheque' issued on 5–6 July 1914? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

46. What diplomatic document did Austria-Hungary deliver to Serbia on 23 July 1914? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

47. What was the German war strategy designed to prevent a prolonged two-front war? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

48. Why did Great Britain officially declare war on Germany at 11:00 pm on 4 August 1914? [ ] Mastered

Answer: _____

Detail / Why: _____

LESSON 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & ALLIANCES

1. **39 independent states** — *Prior to 1871, the German states were loosely connected in the German Confederation, dominated by Prussia and Austria.* [✓][X]
2. **Prussia** — *Prussia used its disciplined military, advanced railway network, and Krupp steel industry to unite the German states under Berlin.* [✓][X]
3. **Otto von Bismarck** — *Bismarck used a pragmatic policy of 'Blood and Iron' (Realpolitik) and three swift wars to achieve unification.* [✓][X]
4. **1871** — *The Empire was proclaimed following Prussia's crushing victory over France in the Franco-Prussian War.* [✓][X]
5. **The Hall of Mirrors at Versailles** — *Staging the coronation inside the historic palace of the French monarchy was a calculated insult that deepened French hatred.* [✓][X]
6. **To isolate France and maintain European peace** — *Bismarck knew a revanchist France could never be reconciled, so he built alliances to deny France any military partners.* [✓][X]
7. **A war on two fronts (Encirclement)** — *Germany feared being simultaneously attacked by France from the west and Russia from the east, dividing its armed forces.* [✓][X]
8. **The Reinsurance Treaty** — *Both powers promised neutrality unless Germany attacked France or Russia attacked Germany's ally, Austria-Hungary.* [✓][X]

LESSON 2: FRANCO-PRUSSIAN WAR & REVANCHE

9. **Alsace-Lorraine** — *Germany seized this mineral-rich border territory for defence and industry, creating an enduring French determination to reclaim it.* [✓][X]
10. **Revanche (Revanchism)** — *French school textbooks, maps (veiled in black), and politicians kept the loss of Alsace-Lorraine alive as an open wound.* [✓][X]
11. **5 billion gold francs** — *Germany intended the indemnity to cripple France economically for a generation, though France paid it off ahead of schedule.* [✓][X]
12. **The Treaty of Frankfurt** — *The treaty codified the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine, the indemnity, and German military occupation until payment was complete.* [✓][X]
13. **Napoleon III** — *His capture brought the immediate collapse of the French Second Empire and the proclamation of the French Third Republic.* [✓][X]
14. **Kaiser Wilhelm II** — *Wilhelm II rejected Bismarck's cautious European diplomacy in favour of personal autocratic rule and aggressive global expansion.* [✓][X]
15. **He allowed the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia to lapse** — *This alienated Tsar Alexander III and left Russia diplomatically isolated and seeking new European partners.* [✓][X]
16. **The Franco-Russian Military Alliance** — *Autocratic Russia and republican France united militarily, realizing Bismarck's worst nightmare of a two-front encirclement.* [✓][X]

LESSON 3: SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA & MOROCCO

17. **The Scramble for Africa** — *European powers colonised 90% of Africa in search of raw industrial materials, prestige, and captive colonial markets.* [✓][X]
18. **The Berlin Conference** — *Hosted by Bismarck, it established the principle of 'effective occupation' to prevent European wars over African land.* [✓][X]
19. **A 'place in the sun' (Platz an der Sonne)** — *Wilhelm II argued that Germany's massive industrial and military power entitled it to a worldwide overseas empire matching Britain's.* [✓][X]
20. **Weltpolitik (World Policy)** — *Weltpolitik abandoned Bismarck's continental focus and sought global naval, colonial, and commercial dominance.* [✓][X]
21. **Tangier** — *He delivered a fiery speech backing the Moroccan Sultan to challenge French dominance and test the strength of the Anglo-French Entente.* [✓][X]
22. **The Algeciras Conference** — *Only Austria-Hungary supported Germany; Britain, Russia, and Italy stood firmly with France, cementing German isolation.* [✓][X]
23. **Germany sent the gunboat SMS Panther to the port of Agadir** — *Germany attempted 'gunboat diplomacy' to extract French colonial territory in the Congo in exchange for recognizing France in Morocco.* [✓][X]
24. **It forged secret Anglo-French joint military and naval planning** — *Rather than driving Britain and France apart, German belligerence convinced Britain that Germany was a dangerous rogue power.* [✓][X]

DEPARTMENT MARKING BANK (PART 2)

Lessons 4 to 6 • Answers 25 to 48 • Core Answers & The Explanation

MARKING KEY 25–48

LESSON 4: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

25. **HMS Dreadnought** — *Dreadnought featured ten 12-inch guns and turbine propulsion, making every existing battleship on the planet instantly obsolete.* [✓][X]

26. **Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz** — *Tirpitz passed the German Naval Laws (1898, 1900) to construct a fleet capable of challenging the British Royal Navy in the North Sea.* [✓][X]

27. **The Two-Power Standard** — *Established by the Naval Defence Act 1889, Britain viewed naval supremacy as strictly vital for its food supply and empire.* [✓][X]

28. **To build a navy so strong that Britain would not risk a battle for fear of crippling itself** — *Tirpitz believed this would force Britain to make diplomatic concessions and grant Germany colonial territory.* [✓][X]

29. **"We want eight and we won't wait!"** — *British public alarm over German naval expansion forced the Liberal government to double its naval construction budget.* [✓][X]

30. **The Kiel Canal** — *Its completion in June 1914 allowed the German fleet to concentrate rapidly, significantly heightening British war fears.* [✓][X]

31. **Britain: 29 dreadnoughts; Germany: 17 dreadnoughts** — *Although Britain won the building race, the naval rivalry destroyed over a century of cordial Anglo-German diplomatic relations.* [✓][X]

32. **It wiped out the British advantage in older pre-dreadnought battleships, resetting the naval race to zero** — *By making older warships obsolete, Germany could compete on equal terms by building only dreadnoughts.* [✓][X]

LESSON 5: ALLIANCE SYSTEM & BALKAN POWDER KEG

33. **Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy** — *The defensive treaty pledged mutual military assistance if any member was attacked by two or more great powers.* [✓][X]

34. **Splendid Isolation** — *Britain focused on its worldwide empire and maintaining the naval balance of power without entangling continental treaties.* [✓][X]

35. **The Entente Cordiale** — *It resolved colonial disputes (Britain in Egypt, France in Morocco) and paved the way for close diplomatic cooperation.* [✓][X]

36. **The Anglo-Russian Convention** — *It ended the century-long 'Great Game' of imperial competition in Asia, clearing the path for joint European alignment.* [✓][X]

37. **Italy held deep territorial rivalries with its alliance partner, Austria-Hungary** — *Italy coveted Italia Irredenta (Trentino and Trieste) ruled by Vienna, leading Italy to declare neutrality in 1914 and switch sides in 1915.* [✓][X]

38. **A localized regional quarrel could instantly trigger a continent-wide chain reaction** — *Pledges of mutual defence meant empires felt compelled to mobilise armies to protect partners, converting a Balkan crisis into World War.* [✓][X]

39. **The collapse of the Ottoman Empire created intense Slavic nationalism and imperial rivalries** — *Austria-Hungary and Russia both competed to dominate newly independent Balkan states like Serbia, creating constant crises.* [✓][X]

40. **The Bosnian Crisis (Annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina)** — *Austria annexed the Slavic province; Germany forced Russia to back down with a military ultimatum, leaving Russia determined never to back down again.* [✓][X]

LESSON 6: SARAJEVO ASSASSINATION & JULY CRISIS

41. **28 June 1914** — *The Archduke, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, was visiting the Bosnian capital on Vidovdan (St Vitus' Day), a Serbian national holiday.* [✓][X]

42. **Gavrilo Princip** — *Princip was a member of Young Bosnia, a revolutionary student movement seeking to unite South Slavs into a Greater Serbia.* [✓][X]

43. **The Black Hand (Union or Death)** — *Led by Colonel Dragutin Dimitrijević ('Apis'), head of Serbian military intelligence, who smuggled weapons and bombs across the border.* [✓][X]

44. **Bosnia contained a large ethnic Serb population that Serbia wanted to incorporate into a Greater Serbian state** — *The 1908 Bosnian Crisis humiliated Serbia and its protector Russia, establishing a bitter blood-feud with Vienna.* [✓][X]

45. **Germany's unconditional promise of total military support to Austria-Hungary against Serbia** — *Kaiser Wilhelm II and Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg encouraged Vienna to strike quickly, gambling that Russia would back down.* [✓][X]

46. **The Austro-Hungarian Ultimatum (The Ten Demands)** — *Deliberately designed to be rejected, it demanded Austrian police enter Serbian sovereign territory to investigate the murder.* [✓][X]

47. **The Schlieffen Plan** — *Conceived by Count von Schlieffen, it planned to conquer France in 6 weeks via* [✓][X]

KEY HISTORICAL FIGURES & ACADEMIC VOCABULARY

The 7 Protagonists • Pronunciation Guide • Core Terminology

PEOPLE & TERMS

THE SEVEN CRUCIAL PROTAGONISTS (1871–1914)

Otto von Bismarck *• Imperial Chancellor of Germany (1871–1890)*
Engineered German unification through "Blood and Iron"; constructed the Triple Alliance and Reinsurance Treaty to isolate France and prevent a two-front war.

Kaiser Wilhelm II *• German Emperor (1888–1918)*
Impulsive autocrat; dismissed Bismarck (1890), dropped the Russian treaty, championed aggressive Weltpolitik, and gave Austria the fatal Blank Cheque (1914).

Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz *• State Secretary of the German Imperial Navy*
Authored the German Naval Laws (1898/1900) and "Risk Theory"; directed High Seas Fleet construction that triggered the naval arms race with Great Britain.

Archduke Franz Ferdinand *• Heir to the Austro-Hungarian Throne*
Targeted by Serbian extremists for his reformist views; his assassination on 28 June 1914 in Sarajevo was the catalytic spark for the outbreak of war.

Gavrilo Princip *• Serbian Nationalist Assassin (Young Bosnia / Black Hand)*
19-year-old student operative who fired the fatal shots in Sarajevo to break the South Slav provinces away from Austria-Hungary into a Greater Serbia.

Sir Edward Grey *• British Foreign Secretary (1905–1916)*
Attempted international mediation during the July Crisis; delivered the British ultimatum to Germany to defend Belgian neutrality under the 1839 Treaty of London.

Helmuth von Moltke (the Younger) *• Chief of the German General Staff*
Executed the Schlieffen Plan; argued that Russian mobilisation meant Germany had to launch an immediate pre-emptive invasion of France via Belgium.

ACADEMIC VOCABULARY WITH SPOKEN PRONUNCIATION GUIDE

Weltpolitik **[Velt-pol-ee-teek]** (GERMAN)
"World Policy." Kaiser Wilhelm II's assertive foreign policy seeking global colonies, international prestige, and naval supremacy matching Britain.

Revanche **[Ruh-vahnsh]** (FRENCH)
"Revenge." The profound, enduring French national desire to avenge defeat in the Franco-Prussian War (1870–71) and reclaim Alsace-Lorraine.

Realpolitik **[Ray-ahl-pol-ee-teek]** (GERMAN)
Pragmatic, hard-nosed statecraft based on practical power and national self-interest rather than moral or ideological ideals.

HMS Dreadnought **[Dred-nawt]** (ENGLISH)
Revolutionary 1906 British battleship with all-big-gun armament and steam turbines, rendering all previous battleships instantly obsolete.

Entente Cordiale **[Ahn-tahnt Kor-dyahl]** (FRENCH)
"Cordial Understanding." 1904 diplomatic accord resolving colonial disputes between Britain and France, paving the way for joint military talks.

Blank Cheque (Blankoscheck) **[Blahnk-oh-sheck]** (GERMAN)
Germany's unconditional pledge of military backing given to Austria-Hungary on 5–6 July 1914, emboldening Vienna to declare war on Serbia.

Mobilisation **[Moh-bi-ly-zay-shun]** (MILITARY)
The complex, timetable-driven movement of reserves, troops, and supplies to frontiers via railways; once ordered, it made war unstoppable.

The Powder Keg of Europe (METAPHOR)
The volatile Balkan peninsula where competing ethnic Slavic nationalisms and Austro-Russian imperial rivalries threatened continental peace.

HOW TO WRITE YOUR END-OF-UNIT ESSAY

Key Stage 3 History • Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

ESSAY GUIDE

YOUR ESSAY QUESTION:

"Why did the First World War break out in August 1914?"

1. THE 4 LONG-TERM CAUSES (M.A.I.N.) & THE 1914 SPARK

Militarism: Britain and Germany competed in a naval race to build Dreadnought battleships and grow huge armies.

Alliances: The Triple Alliance vs. Triple Entente meant a fight between two countries pulled everyone in.

Imperialism: Arguments over colonies in Africa made the Great Powers suspicious and distrustful of each other.

Nationalism: Intense pride and rivalry: France wanted lost land back; Serbian nationalists wanted freedom from Austria.

The Spark (Summer 1914): Franz Ferdinand assassinated in Sarajevo (28 June) → Germany promises to back Austria (5 July) → Austria attacks Serbia → Russia mobilises its army → Germany invades Belgium → Britain enters the war (4 August).

2. WHAT DO HISTORIANS ARGUE? (TWO VIEWS)

Fritz Fischer (Germany Was to Blame):
Germany's leaders wanted a war to dominate Europe. They used the Sarajevo assassination as an excuse to start it.

Christopher Clark ('The Sleepwalkers' — An Accident):
No single country planned a world war. Leaders made reckless decisions, panicked, and stumbled into a disaster they couldn't stop.

3. YOUR 4-PARAGRAPH ESSAY PLAN

Paragraph 1: Introduction: State your main argument straight away—was war planned by Germany, or did leaders stumble into it?

Paragraph 2: The Deep Causes (M.A.I.N.): Explain how the arms race and rival alliances divided Europe into two armed camps.

Paragraph 3: The 1914 Spark: Explain how the Sarajevo assassination pushed alliances and armies into motion.

Paragraph 4: Conclusion: Give your final verdict comparing Fischer vs. Clark. Answer clearly: what was most to blame?

4. SENTENCE STARTERS YOU CAN USE

- *"One major reason war broke out in 1914 was..."*
- *"This increased tension across Europe because..."*
- *"The assassination in Sarajevo was the spark because..."*
- *"On the other hand, historian Christopher Clark argues that..."*
- *"In conclusion, although the M.A.I.N. causes built up tension for years, the decisive factor was..."*

5. USEFUL CONNECTING WORDS & PUPIL CHECKLIST

HELPFUL LINKING WORDS:
As a result • Consequently • Furthermore • However • Most importantly • In contrast

PUPIL CHECKLIST:
[ ] Clear argument in intro • [ ] Explained 2+ M.A.I.N. causes
[ ] Explained the 1914 spark • [ ] Final verdict at the end